

THE AFRICAN SAFARI

Apart from the Bharti-Zain deal, India Inc is spearheading government efforts to establish a strategic foothold in Africa

By Saurabh Shukla and Nivedita Mukherjee

It was 5:25 p.m. in Amsterdam, 8:55 p.m. in India and 6:25 p.m. in Nairobi. The brave new world quite tellingly was being created in the old world, at Amsterdam in the Netherlands. As Sunil Bharti Mittal signed across the dotted line on Tuesday, he created what explorers would call the big footprint. As he shook hands with Zain Chairman Asaad Al Banwan and was congratulated by his Airtel colleagues Akhil Gupta and Manoj Kohli, Mittal was writing a new chapter in Indian entrepreneurship. The \$10.7-billion deal, the second biggest acquisition by an Indian outfit, made Airtel the world's fifth largest telecom player. But more importantly, it made India a major player in the yet uncharted continent of Africa.

Soon after the takeover, in his typically succinct manner, Mittal indicated at the direction of India Inc's ambitions and

said, "We are excited at the growth opportunities in Africa, the continent of hope and opportunity. We believe that the strength of our brand and the historical Indian connect with Africa coupled with our unique business model will allow us to unlock the potential of these emerging markets." This was also the coming together of an unprecedented public private partnership. India Inc and Government of India are working together to expand both commercial influence and geopolitical clout. The two are doing the tango very well.

There is a paradigm shift in India's diplomatic focus on Africa and it is the beginning of a new African Safari, a well calibrated strategy to rediscover the continent which is crucial to spur India's strategic ambitions and its growth story. In a continent where aid has been used as a password for market access, India has been sensitive and

ANATOMY OF THE DEAL

\$ 10.7 bn	Size of the deal
\$ 1.2 bn	Debt
\$ 13 bn	Combined revenue of ZAIN and Airtel
179 mn	Total subscribers
1.8 bn	Population covered